Democrats would use majority to push AI guardrails

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Golf course dispute is more serious than it looks

Democrats would use majority to push AI guardrails. Oversight would be the core of Democratic AI policy in the new Congress, but if Democrats win both chambers, they will likely advance legislation to force Republicans onto the record on AI despite the likelihood of a presidential veto.

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Committee chairs, not the progressive wing, would write Democratic AI bills. These positions would go to more senior members who predate the left-wing wave and have already been drafting AI legislation. Progressives' main role would be to set the bounds of the legislation, while the architecture would be a framework negotiated across the party.
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Democrats would likely push for guardrails and liability rules that clarify who is responsible for AI outputs, behaviors, and harms. They would also likely legislate quickly on areas where bipartisan agreement already exists—export controls and restrictions on frontier model access, as well as child safety, workforce protections, and conditions on data centers.
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The framework Democrats coalesce around in 2027 would be the policy blueprint for the party in the 2028 presidential race. This makes the next few months crucial for those seeking to shape AI policy, and forces the Republican party to similarly create a unified party line on the issue.
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For more, please see Democrats would use majority to reset terms of AI debate , 19 October 2026.

Extradition limits place ceiling on US-Mexico security cooperation. Heightened US scrutiny of illicit financial flows has complemented Mexican President Claudia Sheinbaum's recent efforts to strengthen oversight by Mexican institutions, and we expect bilateral cooperation to deepen. However, Mexico's opposition to US troops on the ground and resistance to extraditing politicians will limit how far the

relationship can progress.

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The Sheinbaum administration has authorized more sophisticated joint training programs and expanded information sharing as well as military-to-military coordination through formal channels. This has increased drug seizures and criminal arrests, and Sheinbaum is betting it will produce enough results to stave off unilateral US action.

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The Trump administration continues to pressure Mexico to show more measurable progress against criminal groups, but we expect Sheinbaum to stick to her current approach.

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Sheinbaum continues to protect politicians with alleged criminal ties as Trump has used indictments in US courts to push for extradition. While we don't expect disagreement on security issues to negatively affect other areas of bilateral relations, like trade, this will continue to be a point of tension.

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For more, please see Extradition limits place ceiling on US-Mexico security cooperation , 19 October 2026.

Golf course dispute is more serious than it looks . The Trump administration appears set to move ahead with plans to begin renovation of the East Potomac golf course in Washington, even though a court order is in place blocking elements of the project for now. The dispute has been unusual for the administration's efforts to remove Judge Ana Reyes from the case and its claims that the Department of the Interior does not need formal approvals to move ahead.

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While content of this dispute may appear trivial—the renovation of a single golf course in DC, a pet project of the president's—its implications are less so. The administration has certainly strained the relationship between the courts and the executive branch at times, but it has rarely been in outright defiance.

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If the administration does push ahead with its plans, this would be an important signal of how it intends to test executive-judiciary relations after the midterms. Even with more concerted domestic pushback in the form of a Democratic-controlled House and/or Senate, Trump is likely to keep pressing the boundaries.

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The spat over East Potomac suggests that even as Trump's policy ambitions may be more limited after the midterms, he will still be able to erode the norms of the US constitutional system even through such apparently small-scale disputes. Trump doesn't need massive, high-profile fights with the courts over issues like tariffs or deportations; instead, norm erosion after the midterms may tend more towards "death by a thousand cuts," making it harder—though not impossible—for institutional norms to return to the status quo ante, post-Trump.

Quote of the Day

"He didn't end the Lindsey Graham sanctions. He's just suspended the enforcement of them for now." - Secretary of Energy Chris Wright, as quoted in an interview with ABC. President Trump's use of a national security waiver to delay, or avoid, sanctions on Russia aligns with our prior view that such a waiver would be the easiest offramp to manage tensions in Ukraine and draw Putin to the negotiating

table (please see Refined product export restrictions likely if prices remain elevated, 16 September 2026). Despite the waiver, it remains possible for sanctions to be placed in the future.

On the Radar

30-31 October: G20 Foreign Ministers' meeting

3 November: National midterm elections

9 November: Congress returns from recess

18-19 November: APEC leaders meeting in China

11 December: Government funding runs out

14-15 December: G20 summit in Florida

10 January: US-China tariff truce expires

Clayton Allen
Practice Head, United States
+1 202.903.0027
allen@eurasiagroup.net
Noah Daponte-Smith
Senior Analyst, United States
daponte-smith@eurasiagroup.net
Kendal Walker
Senior Analyst, United States
walker@eurasiagroup.net
Jason Walter
Researcher, United States
walter@eurasiagroup.net
Scott Bade
Senior Analyst, Geo-technology
+1 202.540.5140
bade@eurasiagroup.net
Matias Gomez Leautaud
Senior Analyst, Mexico
gomezleautaud.ne@eurasiagroup.net
EG US Daily
unitedstates@eurasiagroup.net
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